

Medevac and Treatment

The efficiency of evacuating wounded men by helicopter and the effectiveness of medical treatment in Vietnam sharply lowered the death toll compared to previous American wars, but also led to a larger percentage of survivors with serious permanent injuries.

◀◀ BEFORE

Helicopters were first used by the US to evacuate wounded troops during the Korean War.

IMPROVED RESPONSE

In Korea, Medevac helicopters took soldiers from the front lines to makeshift **Mobile Army Surgical Hospitals**, pioneered by surgeon Michael DeBakey. While this allowed wounded men to be treated much more quickly than before, the war still saw **26 percent of casualties** die from their wounds.

Medical support for US forces increased with the escalation of ground forces. In April 1965, the US Army had one field hospital at Nha Trang with 100 beds, and the US Navy had a dispensary at Saigon. By the end of 1968, there were more than 5,000 beds at Army hospitals, while the USS *Repose* and USS *Sanctuary*—Navy hospital ships—each had capacity for 800 patients.

In South Vietnam, the US created evacuation hospitals, surgical hospitals, field hospitals, and a convalescent hospital. These essentially permanent facilities had air-conditioning, sanitary environments, and high-tech equipment. US Army surgeons were also able to perform blood transfusions—even in the field—and other lifesaving procedures.

The hospitals were staffed with a wide range of surgical and other specialists. Each division of the army had its own medical specialists, including physical therapists, dieticians, and pharmacists. Such roles were not limited to men, and some women served in these capacities.